

The political world

Almost all of the world's land is claimed by countries or nations. The largest nation by area is the Russian Federation, with almost twice the land area of the second-largest, Canada. Some countries have a single neighbor while others have many more. China shares land borders with 16 different countries. A fifth of the world's countries are landlocked, with no direct outlet to Earth's seas or oceans.

Some territories belong to other countries (in this case, to France).



VATICAN CITY

Surrounded by the Italian capital city of Rome, Vatican City is the world's smallest independent state. The center of the Roman Catholic religion, the state has a total land area of just 0.17 square miles (0.44 sq km). That's two-thirds the size of the Disneyland theme park in California.



NEW COUNTRIES

In 2011, South Sudan became independent from Sudan to form the newest country in Africa. New nations can be formed by splitting one country or by joining together separate states. In 1990, East and West Germany reunified to form one country.